

Tapirs

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Mammalia
ORDER	Perissodactyla
FAMILY	Tapiridae
SPECIES	5

These mammals can truly be called “living fossils” because as a group they have changed little over the past 35 million years. They are medium-sized animals with a piglike body on relatively high, slender legs, and a short, extensible trunk. Tapirs live in forest areas (never far from water) in Southeast

Asia and South and Central America. Much of their time is spent in water with just their trunk exposed (like a snorkel), to escape predators and to keep cool. Malayan, mountain, and Baird’s tapirs are all endangered by habitat destruction and hunting.

Anatomy

Tapirs have a streamlined shape, that allows them to move more easily through dense undergrowth. They have a very deep face because their nasal passages are greatly enlarged, with nostrils positioned at the tip of the snout. The sense of smell is acute and is vital in finding food and smelling danger and other tapirs. These animals also have large, erect ears (providing good hearing) and small eyes that are deep in the socket, protected from thorns and sharp branches. Their 3 toes spread out on soft ground, which helps support their weight and prevent sinking. Tapirs



JUVENILE COAT
A red-brown coat with horizontal white stripes and spots is typical of young tapirs. The adult coloration begins to appear at about 6 months.

Tapirus terrestris

Lowland tapir

Length 6¼–7¼ ft (1.9–2.4 m)
Tail Up to 4 in (10 cm)
Weight 400–660 lb (180–300 kg)
Location N. and C. South America
Social unit Individual
Status Vulnerable



This bristly coated tapir has white-tipped ears and a short, narrow mane. It favors waterside habitats, swims well, and dives to escape predators such as pumas and jaguars. Browsing selectively by night, it feeds on a wide range of grasses, reeds, fruit, and other vegetation.

Tapirus pinchaque

Mountain tapir

Length 6–6½ ft (1.8–2 m)
Tail Up to 4 in (10 cm)
Weight 330–440 lb (150–200 kg)
Location N.W. South America
Social unit Individual
Status Endangered



The furriest of the 4 tapir species, the mountain tapir has thick, dark brown to black fur that keeps out the cold of its high-altitude habitat. The lips and ears are usually white-fringed. It eats a variety of dwarf trees and shrubs, mainly at dawn and dusk. Like other tapirs, the mountain tapir hides in thickets by day. Its droppings contain many intact seeds, thereby assisting plant dispersal and consequently forest regeneration. They are solitary animals except for mothers with young.

Tapirus bairdii

Baird’s tapir

Length 6½–7½ ft (2–2.3 m)
Tail Up to 4 in (10 cm)
Weight 550–660 lb (250–300 kg)
Location S. Mexico to N. South America
Social unit Individual
Status Endangered



The largest American tapir, Baird’s is dark brown, with pale gray-yellow cheeks and throat, and white-edged ears. It eats a variety of plant parts,

from buds and leaves to fallen fruit. The gestation period is about 390–410 days and the female produces one young (very rarely 2), which weighs 11–18 lb (5–8 kg). Baird’s tapir uses shrill whistles to communicate with its young or warn other adults away from its territory.



Tapirus indicus

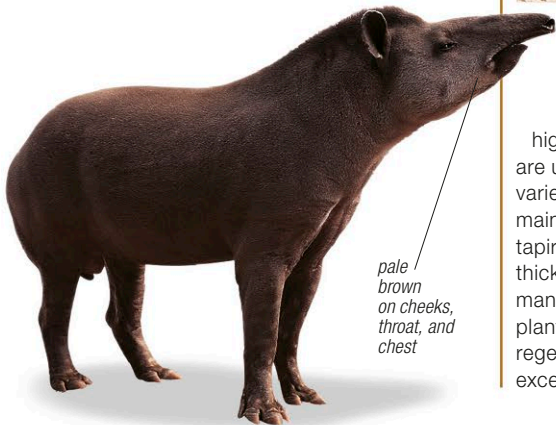
Malayan tapir

Length 8¼–9¼ ft (2.5–3 m)
Tail Up to 4 in (10 cm)
Weight 550–1,190 lb (250–540 kg)
Location S.E. Asia
Social unit Individual
Status Endangered



A striking, 2-tone pattern distinguishes the largest and only Old World tapir. It is black with a white “saddle” over the back and rump, which helps break up its body

outline in shady forests. The Malayan tapir feeds on soft twigs and young leaves of bushes and saplings, and also on fallen fruit. The male’s average range of 4–6 square miles (10–15 square km) overlaps the ranges of several females.



pale brown on cheeks, throat, and chest